A Digna for Bhim

During one of the first sessions I had with Durgabai Vyam and Subhash Vyam, sometime in June 2008, they browsed the books of the masters of the graphic book genre, North American, Franco-Belgian and Japanese—Will Eisner, Art Spiegelman, Joe Sacco, Shaun Tan and Osamu Tezuka. They also looked at Marjane Satrapi's *Persepolis* and the work of some Indian graphic novelists. The Vyams counterposed their own philosophy of art to the visual imagery in these graphic texts (which they described as being by 'fine art school' types): 'We'd like to state one thing very clearly at the outset. We shall not force our characters into boxes. It stifles them. We prefer to mount our work in open spaces. Our art is *khulla* (open) where there's space for all to breathe.' This was a defining moment—we were on to something that would defy the conventional grammar of graphic books. Tiresome photorealism was out of the question. Nor would the Vyams offer cinematic establishment shots, close-ups or extreme close-ups (of tense hands, surprised eyes, furrowed brow), mid-shot, perspective, light and shadow, three dimensionality, aerial views, low angles etc that have come to constitute the mise-en-scène of graphic books. The same character might not appear similar through the book. Durgabai had worked on several picture books, especially for children, but the Vyams or other Gond artists had never explored sequential art. Even when they 'illustrated' children's books, they were known for their full-page renditions.

In fact, since the mid-1990s, once the Pardhan Gond art movement was established by Jangarh Singh Shyam who blazed a trail from his eastern Madhya Pradesh village of Patangarh to Bharat Bhavan in Bhopal, the Pompidou in Paris and the Mithila Museum (of all places) in Niigata, rural Japan, some publishers had begun to extensively use Gond art to illustrate children's books. At Navayana, I had commissioned Durgabai Vyam for a nonfiction book for children in 2007. Durga and Subhash had said then: 'Get us to work on something we have never done before, and on a large scale.' As I became more familiar with the history of the Pardhan Gond art form and its contemporary moorings, I began to comprehend the range, complexity and depth of this genre of artistic expression. I needed to present the Vyams with a challenge that did justice to their sophisticated visual language.

I am the bird speech bubble. My other friends and I appear only for characters whose speech is soft, the lovable characters, the victims of caste—men and women who speak like birds.

Jangarh's Legacy

Before we go further, a brief overview of the origins of Pardhan Gond art is necessary for those who are experiencing their approach for the first time here. Pardhan Gonds, a clan belonging to the larger Gond tribal community in central India, serve as the traditional keepers of their people's cultural heritage and lineages—remembering family genealogies, and transmitting legends, sacred myths and oral histories through songs and storytelling. Pardhan Gond bards are still patronized by the larger Gond community, yet – with customary tribal patronage dwindling over the past century – their traditional livelihood and performance narratives have been made increasingly obsolete.

In the early-1980s, artist Jagdish Swaminathan (1928–1994) – then director of Bhopal's newly founded Charles Correa-designed Bharat Bhavan cultural centre – sent scouts into rural Madhya Pradesh, where one of them spotted the talent of Jangarh Singh Shyam in remote Patangarh. Swaminathan immediately recognized Jangarh's genius and encouraged him to become a professional artist. Since then many Pardhan Gonds have followed in his footsteps. Thus Pardhan songs and oral traditions, which had for centuries been recited to accompany performances on the *bana* (a sacred fiddle), began to be depicted on paper and canvas, as well as in prominent mural commissions—such as on the facade of Madhya Pradesh's legislative assembly building, and on the domes of Bharat Bhavan (now weathered out). At Bharat Bhavan itself, Swaminathan ensured that the works by Pardhan Gonds occupied pride of place alongside the best creations of non-tribal, urban-bound artists. This contemporary expression of Pardhan Gond art has been termed *Jangarh Kalam*, Jangarh Idiom, by poet Udayan Vajpeyi.

I am the thought bubble. Thinking happens with the mind's eye. I contain words that cannot be heard but can be perceived.

In 2001, Jangarh committed suicide under murky circumstances while working as an artist-in-residence at the Mithila Museum in Niigata, rural Japan. By then he had already brought to Bhopal's Professors Colony a wide array of Gond artists, among whom was the married couple Durgabai Vyam and Subhash Vyam (whose sister Nankusia married Jangarh). They, in turn, continued to encourage other Gonds from their village and urban communities to seek a livelihood as professional visual artists, and have generously offered guidance and informal instruction from their modest home and workplace in Bhopal. For instance, during the making of this book, while nine persons lived in the Vyams' two-room household, including Subhash's nephew Sukhnandi Vyam and his family, there would be at least six visitors camping there—doing art, looking for work or just smoking marijuana. 'On a daily basis, 5 kilos of rice and 3 kilos of wheat flour are required in our kitchen,' Subhash once told me. It is the compulsion of supporting such large families that forces major artists like Durgabai or Subhash to be labeled 'craftspersons' and be huddled in 'tribal artist camps' in Delhi or Bangalore where they are offered sometimes a measly Rs 1,000 per day (USD 22) for doing hatched fish-scale patterns on a piece of paper, canvas, or – as it turned out once during the making of the book – paint on metal vases. The approach of some well-networked art aficionados in Delhi is sometimes no different from that of Nike's sweatshops in Vietnam. Tribal-origin artists – even when they can hold their own with their urban compatriots – are relegated to doing the decorative for a daily wage. After all, Jangarh Shyam, when he died in 2001 at the age of 40, was working for just Rs 12,000 a month in the alienating atmosphere of the Mithila Museum run by Tokio Hasegawa. According to art historian Yashodhara Dalmia, a backpacking Hasegawa stumbled upon the animated paintings of Madhubani artists in the 1980s, realized their worth, set up a lucrative business by importing these priceless works to Japan and eventually established a 'museum' in rural Japan. When I approached the Vyams, I was conscious of this history of exploitation that continues to this day.

I am full of words that carry a sting. Characters who love caste, whose words contain poison, whose touch is venomous, speak through me.

In the course of producing *Bhimayana*, Navayana facilitated an exhibition for the brilliant young sculptor Sukhnandi Vyam (Subhash' nephew) at the Wieden+Kennedy gallery in Delhi (March–April 2010). The 17 pieces on display were priced between Rs 80,000 and Rs 2.5 lakh. Not one was sold, but a major statement had been made about the dignity of the artist. A contemporary (non-tribal) artist in Delhi, a self-styled 'collector of tribal art' who has even managed to put together a private museum, said she had been used to buying Gond and other tribal art works for Rs 500. Sukhnandi's show seemed to have shocked and disoriented her. Such exploiters lament the loss of 'innocence of tribal artists' and their 'commercialisation'.

Sukhnandi Vyam's "Artist"

Framing Bhimayana

Just as the unlettered Vyams were unfamiliar with contemporary graphic books, they were unaware of Ambedkar. Their daughter Roshni, 14, an emerging artist – who has done the fish-style font and the numbers used for chapter headings – knew the basic facts though. She told them about the 'guy in the statue in the New Market area with one hand extended, index finger pointing to something afar, another hand holding a book.' Over several sessions, I narrated to them the storyboard, improvising with each telling. I left them with a hand-written Hindi version, for Roshni to read aloud and explain to them. I told them that the text was only a guide to give a sense of direction and they were free to do what they wished. Each brainstorming threw up new insights and also new dead-ends.

Soon, the Vyams were making Ambedkar's story their own. The humiliations Ambedkar faced affected them deeply. They were moved and angered. They internalized the stories. They began cutting out reports of Khairlanji-like incidents from the local papers. By April 2009, the first set of drawings emerged—they turned out to be all full-page works. As promised, there were no panels. Nor would they follow any of the storyboard's technical 'instructions'. We printed a 16-page sampler from the first section of the Water chapter where Bhim is denied water in school. A series of full-page

drawings made it appear like a picture book and threatened to result in an unwieldy and unaffordable 400-pager. We had to come up with an innovative way of panelling and yet not impose the tyranny of conventional panels, without compromising on the credo of not forcing people into boxes. After several frustrating and failed attempts, and months of brainstorming, one muggy Sunday afternoon in August 2009 Subhash suggested that we use the digna – the traditional auspicious design patterns applied to walls and floors in Gond homes – as a way of dividing up a page. He showed me how in rough sketches. A eureka moment! I hugged him. It is in the digna that the origins of Pardhan Gond practice of art lay. Jangarh Singh's murals that now adorn the walls of the Pompidou Centre, or the Bharat Bhavan and the Vidhan Sabha (legislative assembly) buildings in Bhopal originate from the seemingly simple digna. To the left of this page you will see one of the digna patterns that, with subtle variations, forms a leitmotif in *Bhimayana*. Sometimes, entire pages bear this pattern (34–37); at other times deft variations adorn panel borders (22, 28).

The ecology of Pardhan Gond art is such that even when dealing with urban subjects we see freefalling animals, birds and trees in landscapes without a horizon. The train becomes a snake, the intimidating fort a lion. The happiness of the people of Chalisgaon who receive Babasaheb Ambedkar (79) is not conveyed through smiling faces but a dancing peacock. An earthmover used by a dalit, who is killed for digging a well, sheds tears as two cows bear witness (46). As Sirish Rao and Gita Wolf write in the introduction to Bhajju Shyam's *The London Jungle Book* (2005), Gond art does not represent, it signifies. Very early on, the Vyams saw thirsty young Bhim as a fish (17, 19). When I realized that the Vyams loved portraying aquatic life, I suggested they could consider framing some pages like a fish. On page 25, a water tank whose construction young Bhim's father is supervising in Goregaon appears like a fish, as does the common village tank in Satara, fins making room for narrative text. In the preceding page, fishes zero in towards the centre and the Vyams offer an organic approach to paneling. The entire Chakwara story (54) becomes a fish. Ambedkar's historic Mahad speech on the dalit's basic human right to access water reaches the audience through loudspeakers that act as sprinklers—here we see one of the most imaginative and original uses of gutter space in the history of modern graphic art (48). In the next chapter, when a homeless Ambedkar ruminates over his fate in Baroda's Kamathi Garden, he becomes the park (68).

On several occasions Durga and Subhash would introduce narrative elements, situations and characters not provided for in the storyboard. So much that close to 40 percent of the text and dialogue was generated or re-edited to suit the drawings. For instance, page 82 has a neighing horse and four furious faces. In the previous panel, the sister-in-law of Namdeo (the first-time cart driver) blames the horse for tripping the cart and defends her kin. Durga says the horse would surely laugh at this. On page 66, Ambedkar's plight in Baroda is depicted like those of oxen that harness the oil-press, walking in circles and going nowhere. Each time you view a page in this book, you will discover new ways of seeing, new meanings, new pleasures, fresh insights.

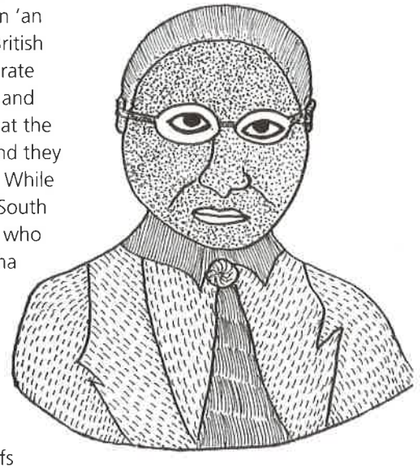
Ambedkar's Missing Story

Navayana was launched in 2003 with *Ambedkar: Autobiographical Notes*, a little 36-page book priced at Rs 40 (about 1 USD back then). In the multi-volume *Babasaheb Ambedkar: Writings and Speeches*, edited by Vasant Moon, these writings can be found in Volume 12 under the title "Waiting for a Visa". The connection between the title and the six autobiographical 'illustrations' – as Ambedkar calls them – is not clear. Perhaps, Ambedkar intended adding more to this body of writing – of less than 10,000 words – but eventually could not. All that the editorial note by Moon says is: 'Here are some of the reminiscences drawn by Dr. Ambedkar in his own handwriting. The MSS traced in the collection of the People's Education Society were published by the society as a booklet on 19th March 1990.—ed.' If these are *some* reminiscences, were there more? What visa was Ambedkar waiting for? We can, however, gather from the content that Ambedkar wrote at least a few of these available notes in 1935. In the second reminiscence, he refers to his return from London to work in Baroda in 1917. Towards the end of this section, he recalls that '18 years has not succeeded in fading away' the memory of the incidence of untouchability he experienced in the Parsi inn in Baroda. It is clear that Ambedkar jotted down several such 'illustrations' over the years, and perhaps many have been lost.

In the storyboard, Srividya Natarajan stuck to Ambedkar's versions of the episodes in letter and spirit but also created new characters and scenarios. In the first two chapters (Water and Shelter) the episodes drawn from Ambedkar's "Waiting for a Visa" are dated accurately, whereas some liberties have been taken with the dates of the events in the Travel chapter. The Mahad satyagraha story does not figure in "Visa", but was included because of its thematic connection. The Gandhi–Ambedkar confrontation at the Round Table Conference in 1931–32, the drafting of the Constitution and Ambedkar's turn to Buddhism have been included to give a sense of completion to Ambedkar's story.

In India today, as in the rest of the world, few outside the dalit movement are familiar with these experiences of Ambedkar. India's hidden apartheid has unfortunately not become a global concern. One of the iconic moments in the global history of anticolonial struggles is considered to be when, in 1893, a 24-year-old Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi is thrown out of the first-class compartment of a train in Pietermaritzburg, South Africa, and he is, in his own words, 'accommodated in a tin compartment where Kaffirs are packed like sheep.' This incident – the horror of being 'degraded' to the level of 'bestial Kaffirs' – is believed to have spurred Gandhi towards his lifelong and tenacious struggle against colonial authority and discrimination. That Gandhi, as a resourceful young lawyer, could afford a first-class ticket in a foreign country is lost sight of. That Gandhi had to go all the way to South Africa to discover racial discrimination, whereas young Bhimrao encountered this as a 10-year-old in Satara, Bombay Presidency, in 1901, is forgotten.

In 1895, when Gandhi encounters two doors to the Durban post office – one for whites and the other shared by Indians and black Africans – he finds it offensive. In 'an appeal to the Indian public' on 14 August 1896, he laments the fate of 100,000 British Indians in South Africa: 'In the Durban Post and Telegraph offices there were separate entrances for natives and Asiatics, and Europeans. We felt the indignity too much and many respectable Indians were insulted and called all sorts of names by the clerks at the counter. We petitioned the authorities to do away with the invidious distinction and they have now provided three separate entrances for natives, Asiatics, and Europeans.' While touchable Gandhi who succeeded in furthering the cause of racial segregation in South Africa came to be recognized as a global anti-imperialism icon, untouchable Bhim who could not drink water in his local school and went on to lead the Mahad satyagraha in 1927 has been neglected by history.



Ambedkar talks of experiencing social equality for the first time in his life during his years in Columbia University; once back in India he is constantly reminded of his untouchability. For Gandhi, the script was played out in the opposite way—the experience of discrimination had to happen far from the social security and comfort that India provides its touchable classes. Today, the same Indian elite that bemoans racial violence and discrimination in Australia snuffs out the lives of two dalits every day. According to the National Crime Records Bureau's statistics for 2008, a crime is committed against a dalit every 18 minutes. On this, there's a chilling silence.

Bhimayana is a small effort to address this anomaly and make Ambedkar's story universal. If the lives and experiences of Martin Luther King and Rosa Parks, Nelson Mandela and Malcolm X could resonate universally, Ambedkar's – and those of millions of dalits in India – ought to as well. After this 'unusually beautiful' rendering of Bhim's story by Durgabai Vyam and Subhash Vyam, there can be no reason not to engage.

Jai Bhim!

S. Anand

I started making dignas at the age of six—using different kinds of clay to draw colourful patterns on walls during festivals and weddings. I've done art work for several books, primarily for children. *The Night Life of Trees*, coauthored by me, won the BolognaRagazzi Award in 2008. I have handled a wide range of themes—from our Gond gods to the horror of the Bhopal gas leak. I really enjoyed drawing Ambedkar's life along with my husband Subhash. While doing the book I once told Anand, this is like the *Ramayana*! He said, 'No, this is ***Bhimayana***'—and that's how we hit upon this title.

DURGABAI VYAM

SUBHASH VYAM

I should say something about myself? Sorry, my number's always busy. Ok, wait... I started working with clay at the age of 10. I used to sculpt in wood. I gave that up since there were no buyers for bulky sculpture. I've since been doing paintings on canvas and paper. Once we cracked a way of doing the panels, the Ambedkar project gave us a lot of scope to experiment with—fusing colours with black for instance. This is my first book and I'm glad Durga and I did this together.

SRIVIDYA NATARAJAN

I'd been a journalist for ten years. Late in 2003, in a moment of madness, and conspiring with my lend-an-idea friend Ravikumar, we started Navayana. He sat me on a tiger and I haven't been able to get off it. It was Ravi who planted the idea of an imaginative visual treatment of Ambedkar's "Waiting for a Visa" in my head.

S. ANAND

I was born in Chennai, India, and now live in London, Canada, and teach English and Creative Writing at King's University College. I trained as a Bharatanatyam dancer, and I've illustrated books for children. My first novel, *No Onions Nor Garlic* (2006), was a comic satire on caste. I storyboarded Jotirao Phule's *Slavery* as a graphic book, *A Gardener in the Wasteland*. I'm now working on my second novel, *Undoing Dance*.

APARAJITA NINAN

As a graphic design student, I worked as an intern with Navayana in 2009–10 towards the graphic novel, *A Gardener in the Wasteland: Jotirao Phule's Fight for Liberty*. I enjoyed creating the font 'Bhim' for this book.

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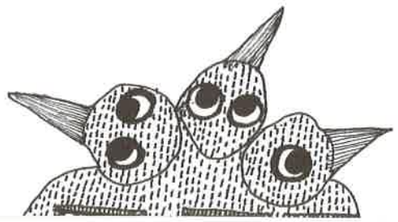
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